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RETHINKING HEALTH INSURANCE POLICIES FOR INTERNATIONAL STUDENTS THROUGH AN EQUITY LENS

A CASE STUDY OF BOWLING GREEN STATE UNIVERSITY

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AGENDA

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OBJECTIVES

01 Explain U.S. health insurance

02 Describe the scale and significance of international student enrollment in the U.S

03 Identify key health-insurance inequities international students face.

04 Recommendation

U.S HEALTH INSURANCE

- U.S. health insurance started as limited, prepaid coverage for specific working middle-class groups.
- Health insurance was introduced on U.S on campuses after World War II, initially serving domestic students who were no longer eligible for family insurance plans (McIntosh et al., 2013).

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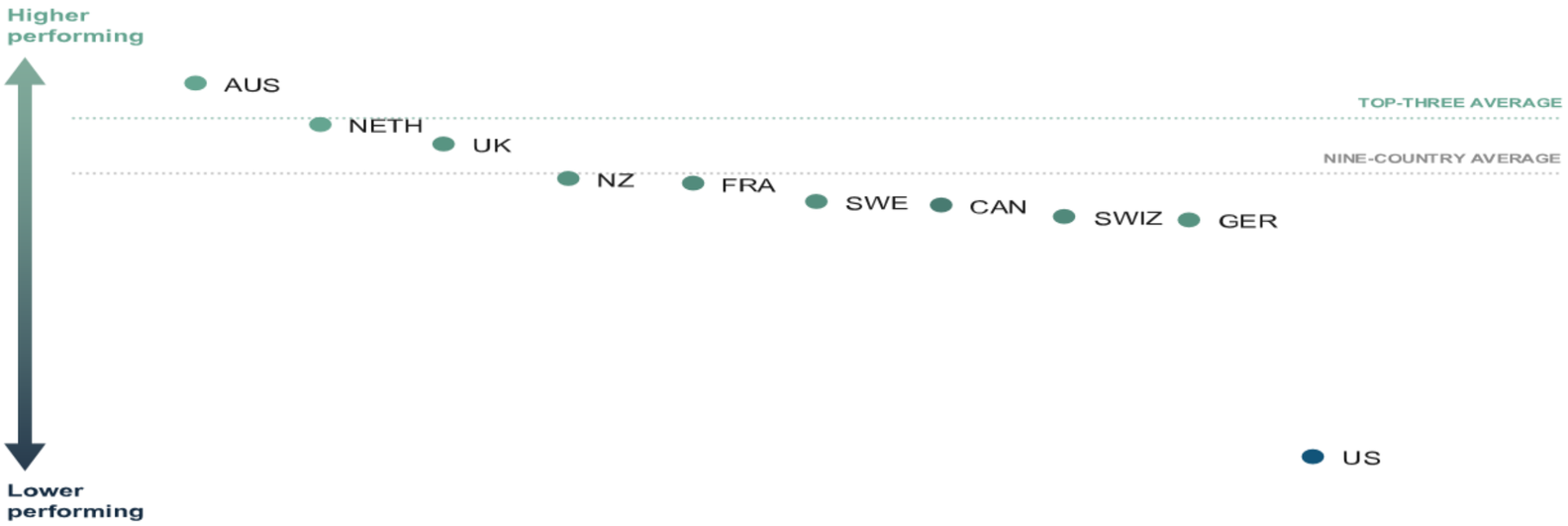
cont..

- Healthcare system in the United States of America (U.S.A.) has been described as efficient but expensive and complex around the world (Paez, Mallery, Noel, Pugliese, McSorley, Lucado, & Ganachari, 2014).

- U.S. health spending reached $5.3T in 2024 ($15,474 per person), about 18% of GDP. (Blumenthal, Shah, & Gunja, 2024).

- In a 10–country comparison, the U.S. ranks last overall on health system performance due to system performance lags



Growth & Contribution of Int. Students

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- International students make up over 6% of the total U.S. higher education population (Institute of International Education, 2025), the U.S. hosted 1,177,766 international students.

- Economically, International students contributed $43.8B and supported 378,000+ jobs in 2023/24 (NAFSA,2024).

- Research, innovation, and campus capacity, International students are heavily represented in graduate study and STEM fields, strengthening research output and program viability at many institutions.

Barriers to Health Access

- High, mandatory premiums are fixed into the cost of attendance.
- Limited access to other affordable insurance plans.
- Out-of-pocket payment (Deductibles, copays)
- University policy often ties insurance to enrollment and immigration status.
- Complex design makes plans hard to navigate

(Adegboyega et al. 2020, Afoakwa-Acheampong 2024, Lenssen, 2010, and Liu et al 2023)

Literature Review

Author(s)	Paper	Results
Lenssen (2010)	Graduate students' health insurance and factors predicting satisfaction	Satisfaction is higher when students understand plan details, have provider choice, and manageable costs
Adegboyega et al. (2020)	Health insurance literacy among international college students	Students lacked understanding of terms like co-pays and deductibles; limited orientation support student
Liu et al. (2023)	Health insurance literacy and medical care avoidance among international students	50% lacked term knowledge, 80% couldn't calculate costs, and 44% avoided care due to confusion and expense
Afoakwa-Acheampong (2024)	Understanding international students' challenges in the U.S. healthcare system	Students experienced fear, cultural mismatch, and stress affecting academic performance

Case Study

- Automatically enrollment onto the university-sponsored health insurance plan upon class registration (BGSU, 2025).
- Insurance fees are processed last when students make partial tuition payments. This means students can't access health care, until their full balance is cleared.
- From an equity lens, the policy treats all students equally but creates unequal impacts by ignoring international students' financial, cultural, and legal challenges (McNair, Bensimon, & Malcom-Piqueux, 2020).
- As Adegboyega et al. (2020) found, international students often arrive in the U.S. with little understanding of the healthcare system. By limiting choice and access, BGSU places them in a structurally disadvantaged position.

Case Study

- The $2,000+ insurance cost adds further burden, forcing students to delay or avoid care due to confusion, fear of bills, and lack of trust in the system.

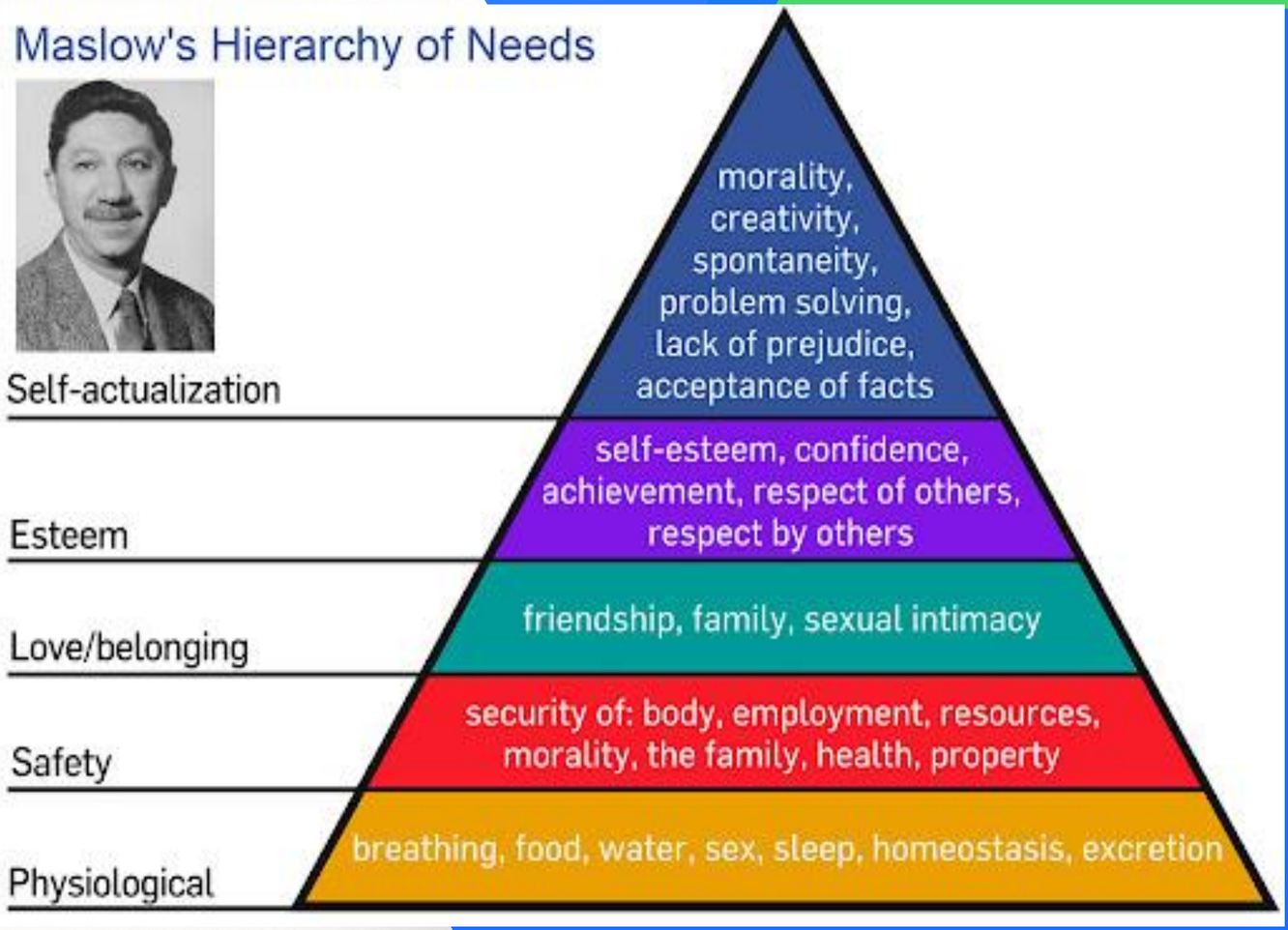
- At Bowling Green State University (BGSU), international students are automatically enrolled in a university-sponsored insurance plan, with no flexible opt-out process (BGSU, 2025).

- This equity audit explores how BGSU's current health policy impact international students using three critical frameworks namely Maslow's Hierarchy of Needs ,Deficit Thinking Framework and Equity-Driven Lens on Internationalization.

- The goal is to move beyond surface-level inclusion toward real, equity-centered reform.

Theoretical framework

- Basic needs like safety and healthcare must be met before students can focus on academics
- When international students can’t access healthcare due to unpaid insurance fees, their academic and emotional well-being suffers (violates this theory)
- Financial barriers delay treatment and disrupt belonging and self-actualization (Liu et al., 2023).



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Deficit thinking Framework (Valencia, 2012)

- Blames students for their struggles instead of addressing loopholes in polices and the administrative system.
- BGSU's policy assumes students must figure out the healthcare system on their own.
- Lack of guidance, confusing processes, and rigid policies place the burden on students not the institution.

Equity-Driven Lens on Internationalization (George Mwangi & Yao, 2021)

- Institutions often treat international students as financial assets, not policy co-creators.
- BGSU's mandatory insurance policy reflects a transactional model.
- Equity means giving students choice, support, and representation in decisions that affect them.

DISCUSSION

Identify one policy or program at your institution that mirrors the BGSU equity gaps

- Where does the burden land? (cost, waiver, deadlines, billing holds, communication)
- Who is most impacted?
- What deficit assumption is built in?
- Who has a voice in the policy design and review?

RECOMMENDATION

Recommendation	Details	Responsible Office/Person	Theory Influence
Mandatory Insurance Education	Offer multilingual workshops during orientation to explain insurance terms, coverage, and provider networks.	International Programs & Partnerships; Health Insurance Office	Maslow's Hierarchy of Needs
Simplify Insurance	Translate key insurance documents and use infographics to improve clarity and access.	Health Insurance Office	Deficit Thinking Framework
Change Fee Payment Order	Prioritize health insurance payments or allow temporary access to healthcare	Bursar's Office; Dean of Students	Maslow's Hierarchy of Needs
Advocate for Policy and Agreement policy	Push for inclusion in public/subsidized plans and allow waiver options and agreement between BGSU and healthcare providers	Dean of Students; IPP; Legal Counsel	Equity-Driven Internationalization
Include Student	Add international students to health policy advisory boards.	IPP; Student Government; Health Center	Equity-Driven Internationalization
Peer Health Navigator	Train upper-year students to support newcomers with healthcare navigation.	IPP; Orientation	Deficit Thinking Framework & Equity-Driven Internationalization
Hire Culturally Competent	Recruit diverse, multilingual healthcare staff trained in cultural humility.	Health Center; Human Resources	Maslow's Hierarchy of Needs & Equity-Driven Internationalization

CONCLUSION

Summary

- BGSU's mandatory insurance policy appears protective but reinforces structural barriers for international students.
- It limits choice, delays access to care and ignores cultural and financial realities.
- Using Maslow's Hierarchy, Deficit Thinking, and Equity-Driven Internationalization, this audit shows the policy prioritizes compliance over care.

Call to Action

- Restructuring support systems
- Centering student voice in decisions
- Moving from a transactional model to a student-centered approach

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CONTACT US

Phone

+419 3433297

Email

ophelim@bgsu.edu

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